The consumer is to be protected against any unfair practices of trade. It is mandatory for the consumers to know these rights. However, there are strong and clear laws in India to defend consumer rights. The most important law is the Consumer Protection Act, 1986. According to this law, everybody including individuals, a firm, a Hindu undivided family and a company, has the right towards the purchase of goods made by them. It is the significant that, as a consumer, everyone should know the basic rights as well as about the courts and procedures that follow with the infringement of one's rights

John F. Kennedy's view on Consumer Rights

The former president of U.S.A Mr. John F. Kennedy defined the basic consumer rights as "The Right of Safety, the Right to be informed, the Right to choose and the Right to be heard."

The consumer is the king of the modern marketing, but in fact he is not. The various rights of consumers guaranteed under the Consumer Protection Act have been discussed here under.

i) Right to Protection of Health and Right of Safety

There may be few products that are more likely to cause physical danger to consumers' health, lives and property. They may contain potentially harmful substances which are dangerous from the consumer welfare point of view. The best examples of this kind are Food additives, colours, emulsifiers, preservatives. The health hazards which are likely to arise have to be eradicated or reduced altogether. In case of food items and drugs both life saving and life sustaining safety is to be guaranteed. One thing that is encouraging to-day is that recent legislations have shifted the responsibility for the production of such unsafe items onto the shoulders of sellers rather than on buyers.

ii) Right to be Informed

Consumers should be given all the relevant facts about the product so that they can take intelligent decisions on purchasing the product. Advertising and labelling on the package should provide objective information to buyers. This implies that manufacturer and the dealer are expected to disclose all the material facts relevant and relating to the product. The package should contain the full details about the name of the product, composition, dosage, date of manufacturing, date of expiry, batch number, warnings, antidote etc. In addition, it should clarify as to the name of the manufacturer, price with or without tax. Such information goes a long way towards saving the consumer against the possible deceit.

iii) Right to choose

Consumer satisfaction is the ultimate aim of modern marketing and is the philosophy of marketing concept. A wise trader or dealer or manufacturer is one who maximises his profits by maximising the consumer satisfaction. Consumer satisfaction can be increased by giving the consumer the widest choice. The term 'Choice' means offering the widest range of products in quality and brand varieties at reasonable prices. In short consumers should have access to varieties of goods in terms of colour, quality, design, size etc.

iv) Right to be Heard

Consumers have every right to ventilate and register his/her dissatisfaction, disagreements and get the complaint heard and aired. This right is vital. Business enterprises should lend a compassionate ear to complaints or grievances of consumers. All business enterprises should have a separate department or wing or segment for addressing consumer grievances.

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